

A Sneak Peek into PHP 7

PHP 7 is a new major version release, arriving 11 years after PHP 5. The scheduled release is before the end of the year. What will this new version have in its repertoire? This article gives the reader a taste of the things to come.

The good news for PHP developers is that PHP 7 RC5 (Release Candidate) is released on October 15, 2015. PHP 7 is in the development phase, so do not use it in a production environment until the final version is out in November. To check when the next beta version will be released, visit <https://wiki.php.net/todo/php70#timetable>. The current stable version is PHP 5.6.14.

Let's now check out some of PHP 7's exciting new features.

The name and new Zend Engine

PHP developers have decided to choose version 7 instead of version 6 to avoid the confusion with past experimental projects. PHP 6 started as an experimental process earlier with a specific set of features. However, it did not reach the production phase. Hence, the developers decided to omit version 6 and instead name their new major release PHP 7.

The Zend Engine has been a core part of PHP since PHP 4. It's an open source execution engine that interprets the PHP language. With the PHP 5 series, the Zend Engine 2 was introduced with a built-in object model and performance enhancing capabilities. PHP 7 comes with the new engine version called PHPNG (Next Generation).

Improved performance

Though the current stable PHP 5.x series is working significantly faster than all its previous versions, the main goal of PHPNG is to get a much better and improved

performance compared to the current versions. PHP 7 with the new engine has remarkably optimised memory usage and the just-in-time compiler does the compilation at runtime rather than prior to execution. Figures 1, 2 and 3 show the performance benchmarks provided by the Zend performance team.

[Reference: http://www.zend.com/en/resources/php7_infographic]

64-bit support

Though a part of the LAMP (Linux, Apache, MySQL, PHP) stack, PHP 7 introduces 64-bit support on Windows systems. It allows the running of both native 64-bit integers and large files on Windows systems.

New operators

PHP 7 comes with two new operators — the null coalesce operator and the combined comparison operator.

The null coalesce operator is denoted by double question marks (??). It returns the first operand if it exists and is not null; otherwise, it returns the second operand. It has the same usage as ternary operators in the C language.

```
<?php
$a = 10;
$b = $a ?? 20;
```